NOVA / YEAR 8

POETRY ANTHOLOGY

Hope • Adversity • Resilience

01 Emily Dickinson

“Hope” is the thing with feathers

02 Thomas Hardy

The Darkling Thrush

A source-checked, UK public-domain poetry pair

Curated for Lesson 037: Comparing two anthology poems on a shared theme.

Includes full poems, line numbers, vocabulary support and comparison tasks.

Original NOVA page design. The historic poem texts remain public domain.

“Hope” is the thing with feathers

EMILY DICKINSON • 1830–1886 • first published 1891

Read once for the image; read again for what the image suggests.

“Hope” is the thing with feathers
That perches in the soul
And sings the tune without the words
And never stops at all,

And sweetest in the gale is heard;
And sore must be the storm
That could abash the little bird
That kept so many warm.

I've heard it in the chillest land
And on the strangest sea,
Yet never, in extremity,
It asked a crumb of me.

VOCABULARY

gale: strong wind abash: unsettle or discourage extremity: great hardship

Focus: how does the bird image make an invisible feeling easier to imagine?

The Darkling Thrush

THOMAS HARDY • 1840–1928 • first published 1900

Notice the shift from the speaker’s bleak world to the bird’s song.

I leant upon a coppice gate
When Frost was spectre-gray,
And Winter’s dregs made desolate
The weakening eye of day.

The tangled bine-stems scored the sky
Like strings of broken lyres,
And all mankind that haunted nigh
Had sought their household fires.

The land’s sharp features seemed to be
The Century’s corpse outleant,
His crypt the cloudy canopy,
The wind his death-lament.

The ancient pulse of germ and birth
Was shrunken hard and dry,
And every spirit upon earth
Seemed fervourless as I.

At once a voice arose among
The bleak twigs overhead
In a full-hearted evensong
Of joy illimited;

An aged thrush, frail, gaunt, and small,
In blast-beruffled plume,
Had chosen thus to fling his soul
Upon the growing gloom.

So little cause for carolings
Of such ecstatic sound
Was written on terrestrial things
Afar or nigh around,

That I could think there trembled through
His happy good-night air
Some blessed Hope, whereof he knew
And I was unaware.

GLOSSARY

coppice: small managed wood • lyres: stringed instruments • crypt: burial chamber
fervourless: without strong feeling • illimited: without limit • nigh: near

The comparison workshop

SHARED THEME

How can hope survive when the world seems harsh or uncertain?

DICKINSON

Hope behaves like a bird

living within a person.

Tone: more assured.

HARDY

A real bird sings in

a bleak landscape.

Tone: more uncertain.

NOTICE → SELECT EVIDENCE → EXPLAIN → COMPARE

1. What idea about hope appears in both poems?
2. Dickinson: identify one image that suggests hope remains strong.
3. Hardy: locate one image of decline and one image of unexpected song.
4. How are their speakers’ feelings about hope different?
5. Write a comparison using evidence from both poems.

COMPARE — NOT TWO SEPARATE SUMMARIES

Both poets present hope as ...

Dickinson suggests ... through ..., whereas Hardy ...

This difference makes the reader ...

TEXT SOURCES / HISTORICAL VERIFICATION

Dickinson: Representative Poetry Online, University of Toronto (1891 text).
Hardy: Academy of American Poets (1900/1901 published poem).
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